

Catching the rain

The **relentless depletion** of groundwater in Punjab and Haryana **has** reached **alarming** levels. **Years** of **unchecked extraction**, intensive irrigation for **water-guzzling** crops and inadequate conservation measures **have** left the water table in a **free fall**. The **launch** of Jal Shakti Abhiyan: Catch the Rain-2025 from Haryana on World Water Day **underscores** the urgency of reversing this crisis. While symbolic initiatives are welcome, **firm** and **sustained** policies are needed to **integrate** rainwater harvesting into its water management strategy.

Punjab and Haryana have seen groundwater levels **plummet** due to over-reliance on borewells and canal irrigation. Studies indicate that **wells** in some parts of the region **are witnessing** an annual water table decline of over a metre, with **desertification looming**. Yet, rainwater harvesting adoption remains **sluggish**. It is **plagued** by financial **constraints**, **bureaucratic red tape** and a lack of awareness. Regulatory hurdles, complex approval processes and **inconsistent enforcement** of rainwater harvesting **mandates** further **deter** its widespread implementation.



To **combat** this, Haryana's Mukhyamantri Jal Sanchay Yojana and initiatives like the Integrated Water Resource Action Plan (2025-27) must go beyond **tokenism**. **A clear roadmap**, **backed** by financial incentives and technological innovation, **is** crucial. Property tax **rebates** for households implementing rainwater harvesting, as seen in Indore, **should** be **replicated** across north India. Additionally, urban planning must integrate rainwater harvesting into building codes, ensuring that new developments contribute to groundwater recharge. Rural **outreach** is equally **vital**. **Equip** farmers **with** knowledge of efficient irrigation techniques to reduce their dependence on groundwater. Solar-powered micro-irrigation **projects**, as launched in Haryana, **should** be **expanded** to Punjab. **Moreover**, reviving traditional water bodies and **desilting** village ponds can **aid** in water retention and **percolation**. Water **scarcity** is no longer a **distant** threat — it is a present crisis.

[Practice Exercise]

- Red/blue coloring of words in the sentence indicates subject verb relationship; where 'red' denote 'subject' and 'blue' denotes 'verb'.
- **Outreach** (noun) – The act or process of reaching out. पहुँच

Vocabulary

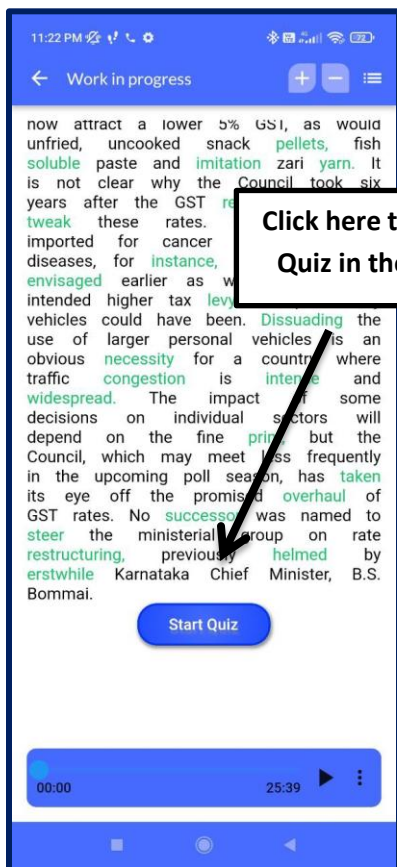
1. **Relentless** (adjective) – Persistent, Unceasing, Unrelenting, Continuous, Inexorable निरंतर
2. **Depletion** (noun) – Reduction, Exhaustion, Drainage, Decrease, Diminishment कमी
3. **Alarming** (adjective) – Worrying, Disturbing, Frightening, Shocking, Troubling चिंताजनक
4. **Unchecked** (adjective) – Uncontrolled, Unrestrained, Unregulated, Unbridled, Unmonitored अनियंत्रित
5. **Extraction** (noun) – Removal, Withdrawal, Pumping, Drawing out, Mining निष्कर्षण
6. **Water-guzzling** (adjective) – Water-intensive, Thirsty, High-consumption, Water-draining पानी की अधिक खपत वाला
7. **Free fall** (noun) – Rapid decline, Sudden drop, Plunge, Collapse, Descent निर्बाध गिरावट
8. **Underscore** (verb) – Emphasize, Highlight, Stress, Accentuate, Reinforce जोर देना
9. **Firm** (adjective) – Strong, Resolute, Determined, Steadfast, Unwavering दृढ़
10. **Sustained** (adjective) – Continuous, Prolonged, Persistent, Steady, Uninterrupted निरंतर
11. **Integrate** (verb) – Incorporate, Combine, Merge, Blend, Unify एकीकृत करना
12. **Plummet** (verb) – Plunge, Drop, Fall sharply, Decline rapidly, Crash तेजी से गिरना
13. **Witness** (verb) – Observe, See, Experience, Watch, Notice देखना
14. **Desertification** (noun) – Land degradation, Aridification, Soil erosion, Droughtification मरुस्थलीकरण
15. **Looming** (adjective) – Impending, Approaching, Forthcoming, Imminent, Upcoming निकट होना
16. **Sluggish** (adjective) – Slow, Lethargic, Inactive, Sluggard, Torpid सुस्त
17. **Plague** (verb) – Afflict, Trouble, Beset, Harass, Torment परेशान करना
18. **Constraint** (noun) – Limitation, Restriction, Obstacle, Hindrance, Barrier बाधा
19. **Bureaucratic** (adjective) – Administrative, Official, Procedural, Governmental, Red-tape नौकरशाही
20. **Red tape** (noun) – Bureaucracy, Formality, Paperwork, Regulation, Officialism लालफीताशाही
21. **Inconsistent** (adjective) – Irregular, Unreliable, Erratic, Variable, Unsteady असंगत

22. **Enforcement** (noun) – Implementation, Execution, Application, Imposition, Regulation प्रवर्तन
23. **Mandate** (noun) – Directive, Order, Decree, Command, Requirement आदेश
24. **Deter** (verb) – Discourage, Prevent, Hinder, Dissuade, Inhibit रोकना
25. **Combat** (verb) – Fight, Tackle, Counter, Resist, Oppose मुकाबला करना
26. **Tokenism** (noun) – Symbolic gesture, Empty formality, Pretence, Superficiality दिखावटी कार्रवाई
27. **Back** (verb) – Support, Endorse, Fund, Finance, Advocate समर्थन करना
28. **Rebate** (noun) – Discount, Refund, Deduction, Reduction, Allowance छूट
29. **Replicate** (verb) – Copy, Duplicate, Reproduce, Imitate, Mirror दोहराना
30. **Vital** (adjective) – Essential, Crucial, Important, Necessary, Critical महत्वपूर्ण
31. **Equip** (with) (verb) – Provide, Supply, Furnish, Arm, Outfit सुसज्जित करना
32. **Expand** (verb) – Increase, Grow, Extend, Broaden, Develop विस्तार करना
33. **Moreover** (adverb) – Furthermore, Additionally, Besides, Also, In addition इसके अलावा
34. **Desilt** (verb) – remove silt from (a body of water). मिट्टी या रेत हटाना
35. **Aid** (verb) – Help, Assist, Support, Facilitate, Boost सहायता करना
36. **Percolation** (noun) – Seepage, Filtration, Infiltration, Drainage, Leakage रिसाव
37. **Scarcity** (noun) – Shortage, Lack, Deficiency, Insufficiency, Dearth कमी
38. **Distant** (adjective) – Far-off, Remote, Faraway, Future, Long-term दूर का

Summary of the Editorial

1. **Groundwater depletion in Punjab and Haryana** has reached **critical levels** due to years of over-extraction and poor conservation.
2. The **main cause** is the **overuse of borewells** and **canal irrigation** for water-intensive crops like paddy.
3. Studies show that in some areas, the **water table is falling by over a metre annually**, raising fears of desertification.
4. Despite the situation, **rainwater harvesting remains poorly adopted** in both states.
5. **Financial issues, bureaucratic delays, and low public awareness** hinder the spread of rainwater harvesting systems.
6. **Regulatory challenges** and **complex approval processes** also discourage widespread implementation.
7. The **Jal Shakti Abhiyan: Catch the Rain-2025** was launched from Haryana on World Water Day to raise awareness.
8. However, the editorial stresses that **symbolic efforts are not enough**; long-term policy actions are required.
9. Haryana's **Mukhyamantri Jal Sanchay Yojana** and the **Integrated Water Resource Action Plan (2025-27)** must move beyond tokenism.
10. The editorial suggests **financial incentives**, such as **property tax rebates**, for households adopting rainwater harvesting — like in Indore.
11. **Urban planning should mandate rainwater harvesting systems** in building codes for new constructions.
12. There is a need to **educate farmers on efficient irrigation techniques** to reduce groundwater dependency.
13. Haryana's **solar-powered micro-irrigation projects** should be expanded to Punjab as well.
14. Revival of **traditional water bodies** and **desilting of ponds** is essential to improve groundwater recharge.
15. The editorial concludes by warning that **water scarcity is not a future threat — it is a current crisis** requiring immediate and sustained action.

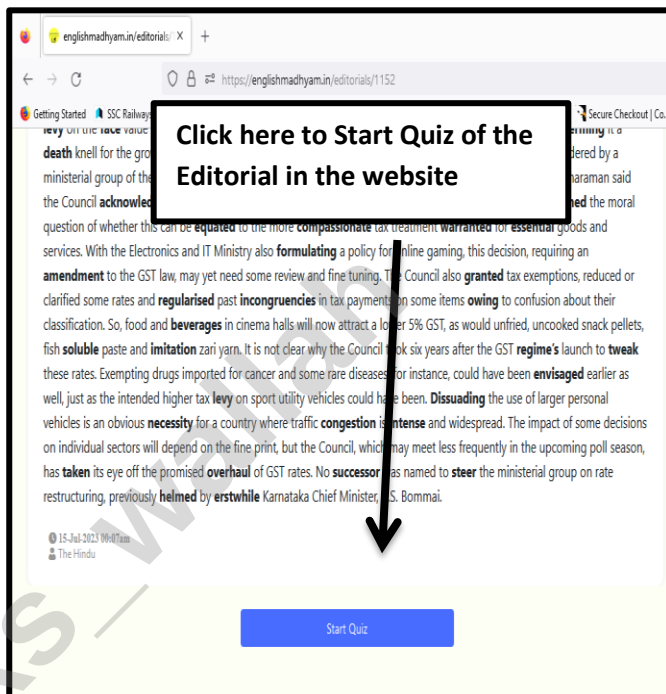
Practice Exercise: SSC Pattern Based



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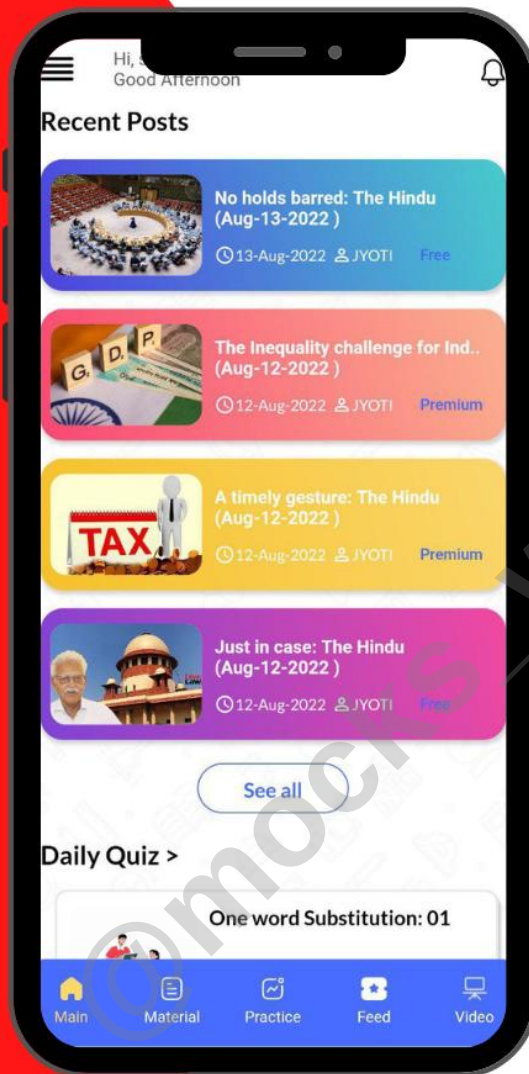
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